steady as we fall.

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/59793856.

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General Audiences

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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steady as we fall.

by lovixcore

Summary

After a long day apart, Adora returns home to find Catra struggling with her emotions. As they reconnect, both share quiet moments of vulnerability, comfort, and reassurance, reminding each other how much they mean to one another. Through tender words and gentle touches, they navigate their complex feelings and find peace in each other's arms, letting love and trust carry them forward together.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Catra’s fingers drummed lightly against the edge of the bed, their rhythm betraying her growing impatience. It felt like hours had passed, though in reality, it had only been a few since Adora left for her duties as She-Ra, the guardian of Etheria. Catra knew how important Adora’s role was—how necessary it was for her to be out there protecting the peace, even in times of calm. But no matter how much she understood, a selfish part of her ached for Adora’s presence. She wanted her here, now, beside her.

Her other hand absentmindedly traced slow circles along Melog’s back, the soft purring of the creature filling the quiet room. Though Melog appeared relaxed, they seemed to sense the tension radiating from Catra, gently nudging her hand as if to ask what was wrong.

Catra offered a faint smile, her voice barely above a whisper. "I'm fine, Melog... don’t worry about me."

But she wasn’t fine. A long, tired sigh escaped her lips, one she had been holding back for what felt like forever. She hated how restless she felt, how dependent she was on Adora’s return. It made her feel clingy, and part of her resented that. But the truth was, Adora had become her world. The one constant in her life that made sense. And yet, only months ago, everything had been so different.

Back then, she thought she had everything she wanted. Power, control, a place in the Horde. But the darkness she embraced only masked the deep fractures in her heart. She had been angry, hateful, willing to destroy everything and everyone rather than let

anyone in. Love was something foreign, something she had convinced herself she didn’t need.

Catra shifted, lying back against the pillows, her mind drifting deeper into those memories. Guilt washed over her. She had Adora now—the one thing she had always wanted but was too stubborn to admit. Adora had loved her, fought for her, even when Catra had pushed her away. And still, despite all the redemption, all the victories they had won together, the guilt lingered. How could she ever make up for the damage she had caused? She had hurt so many, done so much wrong, and no apology could ever erase that. Not even Adora’s reassurances could fully quiet the shame she felt.

Her stomach twisted as her thoughts spiraled. She sat up again, casting her gaze toward the ceiling, lost in the soft glow of the decorations that hung above. It still felt unreal, being here in Brightmoon, living what felt like a dream. She had her happily ever after, as cliché as it sounded, but it wasn’t without its scars.

She was better now—happier. But the mischief, the sarcasm, the ill-tempered nature that had always been a part of her still lingered. She wasn’t perfect, far from it, but she had found something she never thought she deserved—peace, love, and a future. And yet, the past clung to her, a shadow she couldn't quite shake, even in this new life with Adora.

Time seemed to slip away as Catra’s thoughts drifted between her past and present. The creak of the door snapped her out of her reverie, and she heard soft footsteps approaching. She sat up, her eyes landing on the familiar figure standing in the doorway. Adora. Her golden blonde hair fell past her broad shoulders, and her

crystal blue eyes sparkled in the soft light, making Catra's heart race.

Adora stood there with a gentle, loving expression, and the sight of her made Catra blush instantly. A wave of excitement surged through her, a familiar warmth that only Adora could ignite. It had only been a few hours since they last saw each other, but to Catra, it felt like an eternity. Without hesitation, she got up from the bed and rushed toward Adora, wrapping her arms around her tightly. The sudden embrace took Adora by surprise, and Catra could feel the heat rising in her own cheeks as she held on, squeezing her love close.

Adora's hand gently rested on Catra's head, her other arm slowly encircling Catra's waist, pulling her in closer. "Awww, did someone miss me?" she teased softly.

Catra's face burned even hotter at the sound of Adora's voice. To her, it was like honey—sweet and soothing, something she could listen to forever. Embarrassment quickly followed the affection, and Catra, true to her nature, pushed Adora away lightly, muttering, "Shut up!" The sudden shift left Adora looking a little startled, and in a flustered attempt to cover her feelings, Catra crossed her arms, adding with forced sarcasm, "I was just bored. It's not like I missed you or anything."

"Are you sure?" Adora replied, raising an eyebrow playfully, the mischievous grin tugging at her lips.

Catra averted her gaze, trying to keep her composure. “Yes—me being affectionate has nothing to do with missing you or anything like that, dummy,” she said, avoiding eye contact.

Adora chuckled, knowing better. She found Catra’s attempts to mask her feelings adorable, especially since joining the Rebellion had made it harder for her to hide her true emotions. The blush on Catra’s cheeks deepened, but this time, she gave in. Leaning in, she kissed Adora softly on the lips, surprising her. Adora’s initial shock melted into warmth as she kissed back, deepening the moment. After a few tender seconds, Catra pulled away, but only to wrap her arms around Adora again, resting her head against Adora’s chin.

Adora smiled, her hand gently running through Catra’s thick hair, now at shoulder length. She leaned down and placed a soft kiss on Catra’s forehead, her heart full as she held the person who meant the world to her.

“You’re… a terrible liar,” Adora whispered softly into Catra’s ear. She noticed a few strands of Catra’s hair falling over her face and instinctively reached out, gently tucking them behind her ear. The small gesture earned her a loud purr from Catra, making Adora smile.

Catra’s face flushed a deep shade of red, her usual orange-tan cheeks now turning vermillion with embarrassment. Her eyes widened in response to the intimate touch. “Shut up!” she squeaked, her voice sharp and defensive. Adora couldn’t help but giggle at Catra’s reaction, finding her sudden outburst endearing.

Without missing a beat, Catra buried her face in the crook of Adora's neck, nuzzling her before playfully nibbling at the soft skin.

"Ow, Catra!" Adora yelped, laughing despite herself as she felt Catra's teasing bites getting firmer. She knew exactly what Catra was doing—trying to get back at her, trying to rile her up—and it was working. After a few more playful nibbles, Adora finally managed to wiggle free, laughing uncontrollably as she backed away.

The laughter died down when Adora noticed Catra's sultry, half-hearted glare. Immediately, Adora's playful smile softened into something more apologetic. "Hey, hey! I'm sorry, you know I can't resist teasing you," she said, her tone shifting to something more tender. Leaning in, Adora cupped Catra's face, her thumb brushing gently against her cheek. "You're just so cute…"

"Heh…" Catra muttered, clearly flustered by the compliment. Her previous irritation melted into something warmer, softer. "You… think I'm cute?" she asked, her expression turning from annoyed to gentle. It was impossible for her to stay mad at Adora, even when she tried.

"Adorable," Adora responded without hesitation, her voice dripping with sincerity.

The warmth in Catra's cheeks deepened, and for a moment, she felt utterly overwhelmed. Her palms grew sweaty, and she instinctively hunched her shoulders, feeling the weight of the

compliment. “Ugh!” she groaned in frustration, shoving Adora playfully before crossing her arms and glaring. “You’re so sappy… I hate it.”

Adora just rolled her eyes, the soft smile never leaving her face. She reached out again, this time taking Catra’s hands in hers, intertwining their fingers. “You know you love it… and you know you love me.”

Catra huffed, trying to hold on to her mock indifference. “Eh, I guess it’s true… somewhat.”

“Only somewhat?” Adora teased, raising an eyebrow.

Catra rolled her eyes as she let go of Adora’s hands, pushing her onto the bed with ease. She quickly straddled Adora, a huge smirk spreading across her face, eyes half-lidded with playful mischief. “Fine… a lot,” she admitted, though her voice held a begrudging tone.

But Adora wasn’t about to let Catra win that easily. With a sudden, unexpected move, she flipped Catra over, now pinning her beneath her. Adora leaned over her, a genuine smile tugging at her lips as a warm, intimate giggle escaped. She reached out, her hand brushing Catra’s cheek before her thumb lightly grazed Catra’s lips.

Catra’s eyes widened, her skin heating up uncontrollably at the tender touch. Adora’s thumb ghosted over her lips, sending a shiver down Catra’s spine. The teasing touch was too much, and despite her best efforts, a wide smile broke across Catra’s face. Her eyes crinkled with amusement as she burst into soft laughter, the sound light and airy like a hummingbird’s wings.

"Ah, stop! T-That tickles!" Catra protested between giggles, pushing Adora’s face away playfully.

After a few moments of playful torment, Adora relented, lying back on the soft, bubblegum-pink sheets. She gazed up at the ceiling, still chuckling softly, as Catra settled next to her, resting her head on Adora’s chest like it was the most natural place in the world. Adora’s fingers combed through Catra’s cedar-brown hair, twirling strands around her pinky, before moving to gently stroke Catra’s ears. The rhythmic, soothing touches were pure bliss, and Catra melted into them, feeling completely at peace.

Minutes passed in comfortable silence until Catra’s voice broke through, groggy and hoarse from the warmth of the moment. “You know… maybe I did miss you today.”

Adora’s lips curled into a warm, asymmetric smile, though something about it felt different this time—tinged with wistfulness, maybe even a hint of guilt. Catra couldn’t quite figure it out, but she noticed. Adora’s fingers trailed down the side of Catra’s face as she whispered softly, “I know… I missed you too.”

Adora sighed, the sound almost lost in the quiet room. “I wish you could come with me more often. It’s not fair that you don’t get to.” The words were heavy with longing, and Catra felt them resonate deep in her chest.

Catra rolled her eyes—not out of annoyance with Adora, but because she always found the rules of being a princess so... restrictive. It didn’t seem fair for Adora to always be so uptight, noble, and responsible, even with the war long over and Horde Prime defeated. She gently wrapped an arm around Adora’s waist, resting her head against Adora’s chest. “Yeah... but you know, princess stuff is for ‘princesses only,’” Catra teased, her tone playful, almost mocking.

Adora threw her head back and laughed, the sound light and joyous. Catra could listen to her laugh for hours, entranced by the sweetness of it. The way Adora’s laughter made her heart flutter was fascinating, almost hypnotic. A warmth spread through Catra’s body, her face flushing as she leaned into Adora, allowing herself to fall even more deeply in love. A tingly sensation raced through her veins, and she pressed her face further into Adora’s chest, feeling Adora’s hand gently stroke the back of her head.

Minutes passed in a comfortable, tender silence. Adora’s fingers continued to thread through Catra’s hair, while Catra absentmindedly traced her fingers down Adora’s abdomen, resting peacefully against her chest. Even without words, the silence between them was far from awkward. It was safe, intimate.

After a while, Catra lifted her head from Adora’s chest, her eyes half-lidded with exhaustion. Without thinking, she blurted out, “I love you...”

Adora’s eyes widened, clearly caught off guard. The weight of Catra’s words hung in the air, leaving Adora momentarily speechless. Catra sat up, untangling her legs from Adora’s, her face flushed—not from warmth this time, but from anxiety. Her hands were suddenly sweaty, her heart pounding in her chest. “W-what? Did I… did I say something wrong?”

Adora quickly sat up, reaching out and placing a hand on Catra’s shoulder, squeezing it lightly. But the touch made Catra flinch, her body reacting instinctively as her claws extended and her ears flattened. Adora immediately pulled her hand back, her face flushing with embarrassment. “Sorry! I forgot... I know you don’t like being touched like that,” she said, her voice filled with remorse, remembering the scars Horde Prime had left on Catra.

Catra didn’t respond with words, but instead took Adora’s hand in hers, giving it a gentle, reassuring squeeze. Adora exhaled, steadying herself before continuing. “No, you didn’t do anything wrong. It’s just... it surprises me, in a good way, when you tell me you love me. You don’t say it often, and I don’t expect you to.”

The tension in Catra’s shoulders slowly eased as her posture relaxed, her ears unfolding. She couldn’t help but giggle at how adorably dorky Adora could be, and with that giggle came a wave of gratitude. Catra appreciated Adora’s gentle respect for her boundaries, how she always considered her wants and needs without hesitation. A wobbly smile tugged at Catra’s lips as she murmured, “Well… I guess I’ve had a lot on my mind. I know you don’t expect me to say ‘I love you’ all the time, but I don’t want you to think that means I don’t care. I’m happy…” She paused,

giving Adora's hand a soft squeeze. "So happy... that we have this. But sometimes... I feel like I'm not good enough for you."

Adora's expression shifted from surprise to shock, her face falling as the weight of Catra's words sank in. Her hands slipped out of Catra's grasp for a moment, only for Adora to quickly grab them again, as if anchoring herself to Catra. "What? Are you serious?" Adora's voice was thick with disbelief. Catra's ears flattened again, her heart pounding as Adora's voice took on an urgent, almost panicked tone. "Catra! You're more than enough for me! I... I love you."

"I know, I know…" Catra rolled her eyes, though her voice held none of its usual sharpness. She absentmindedly rubbed her thumb over the back of Adora's hand in slow, circular motions, letting out a long, reluctant sigh. "This is going to sound really sappy and dumb, and you better not tease me about it—" She cut herself off, raising a finger at Adora in mock warning, before her defenses crumbled. Blushing for what felt like the millionth time that night, Catra tucked loose strands of hair behind her ear. "You… you mean so much to me. You've given me so much, and you make me feel… good. But sometimes I feel like I can never live up to everything you give me."

Adora reached for Catra's hand again, gently, as if to reassure her. Catra tightened her grip, but not too much, her claws lightly grazing Adora's soft skin. She glanced down at their hands, then back up at Adora. A shy smile tugged at her lips as she bit her bottom lip, her gaze meeting Adora's with both tenderness and uncertainty. Adora gave her a reassuring smile, her voice a soft coo, "Catra… that's not true, and you know it."

But as Catra smiled, something bitter crept into the edges of her expression. She wasn't upset with Adora, not really—but she was haunted by the memories of her past, of the destruction and pain she had caused. Sardonic laughter bubbled up from her throat, filling the quiet room with a sharp, unsettling sound. Adora flinched slightly at the abrupt shift, but Catra quickly stilled, the smile fading from her face. Her voice turned firm, cold. "Adora."

Adora tensed at the sudden seriousness in Catra's tone, her gaze steady but filled with concern. A small, bitter smirk curled at the edges of Catra's lips as she continued, "I tried to end the world because I was so desperate for your attention. Everything I did—leading the Horde, following Hordak—it was all just me hurting you… hurting everyone."

Adora lifted her hand, gazing into Catra's heterochromatic eyes, uncertainty flickering in her crystal blue gaze. The weight of everything that had happened between them lingered, but so did the love she could never let go of. Gently, Adora cupped the side of Catra's face with her porcelain hand, her fingers tracing a familiar path. She glanced down at their joined hands, her grip tightening slightly in reassurance. "I know. You put me through a lot, and what you did... it was awful," she said softly, her voice tinged with both sadness and understanding. "But I always knew there was good in you. For a while, I lost hope... but we're past that now. You've changed so much."

Catra leaned into the warmth of Adora's palm, seeking the comfort she still doubted she deserved. But the guilt gnawed at her, and she instinctively pushed Adora's hand away, her heart twisting with the familiar sense of not being enough. The rejection made Adora's eyebrows raise, her face softening with hurt before furrowing in concern. Catra clenched her fist, frustration building.

“But... it’s still hard to forgive myself,” she admitted, her voice breaking slightly. “For everything I did. To you, Glimmer, Scorpia, Entrapta... all of Etheria. I don’t deserve any of this, Adora, and I don’t understand why you keep insisting I do.”

Catra’s chest tightened with guilt, the familiar burden of her past bearing down on her once again. Even now, with Adora beside her, safe in her arms, the memories of the pain she had caused refused to fade. She tried to push the thoughts away, but they kept clawing at her, reminding her of everything she believed she didn’t deserve.

Adora, having sensed this all too often, crossed the room with gentle steps. She had seen it in the way Catra’s shoulders tensed, how her gaze dropped to the floor—the telltale signs of a battle Catra couldn’t seem to stop fighting. Without hesitation, Adora wrapped her arms around Catra, pulling her close, offering the steady warmth Catra needed.

“I know,” Adora whispered, her breath soft against Catra’s ear as she ran her fingers in soothing motions down Catra’s back. She had grown familiar with these moments, where panic overtook Catra, rooted in all the guilt she carried. Adora had learned how to steady her—patient, constant.

Catra felt herself relax into Adora’s embrace, the tightness in her chest loosening ever so slightly with every stroke of Adora’s hand. She pressed her face into the crook of Adora’s neck, inhaling her scent—something about it always calmed her, reminded her that she wasn’t alone anymore.

“I love you... so much,” Catra whispered, her voice trembling. She pressed a soft kiss to Adora’s neck, trying to convey everything she felt. “You mean so much to me... I don’t know where I’d be without you.”

Adora’s heart ached at the vulnerability in Catra’s voice, and she pulled her even closer, her arms tightening protectively around her. “You say that like I wouldn’t be completely lost without you,” Adora replied, a soft smile playing on her lips as she rested her cheek against Catra’s head.

Catra lifted her head slightly, looking up at Adora with intensity. “Well... would you?”

Adora met Catra’s gaze, her blue eyes filled with nothing but love. “Catra, I’ve always loved you. I’ve always needed you,” she said firmly, her voice unwavering. “I always wanted this. I always wanted us. I never wanted anything else.”

Catra’s heart fluttered, her cheeks heating with a deep blush. The kindness in Adora’s words overwhelmed her—she still couldn’t quite grasp how someone could love her so completely, despite everything. Leaning in, she kissed Adora softly on the lips, her fingers brushing against Adora’s cheek as she whispered, “You’re too kind…”

Adora smiled warmly, her lips tingling from Catra’s kiss. She gently pressed her lips to Catra’s jawline, leaving a slow, deliberate kiss before pulling back slightly. “I’m being genuine,” she murmured, her lips brushing Catra’s again. “I love you, Catra.”

Catra’s heart swelled with love and relief. She kissed Adora again, deeper this time, letting the weight of everything they had overcome dissolve into the warmth of Adora’s affection. When they finally pulled away, Catra felt a wave of exhaustion sweep over her, her body craving rest after so much emotion.

Wordlessly, she lay down on the bed, pulling Adora with her. Adora followed, wrapping her arms around Catra as they settled into the comforting quiet of the room. The warmth between them was all the reassurance Catra needed, as she nestled into Adora’s chest, listening to the steady rhythm of her heartbeat.

Adora’s fingers moved gently through Catra’s hair, tracing soothing circles on her back. “I love you,” Catra whispered, her voice heavy with sleep, the tension finally easing from her body.

Adora smiled softly, pressing a kiss to Catra’s head. “I know. I love you too.”

The words lingered in the peaceful silence, wrapping them both in the comfort of their love. Slowly, Catra’s breathing steadied as sleep overtook her, her body fully relaxing into Adora’s embrace.

Adora watched as Catra drifted off, her own heart full. No matter what had happened before, no matter the darkness they had faced, they had each other now. And in that moment, it was all that mattered.

Adora smiled down at Catra, her voice a soft whisper, “I’ll always be here.” With that, she allowed herself to close her eyes, holding Catra close as they both drifted into a peaceful sleep, tangled together in the quiet safety of each other’s love.

End Notes

This has been sitting in my drive since 2020/2021.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!